

Patch Cable — User Manual

Virtual audio cables and per-app routing for macOS, by The WAV Lab. Version 1.1.1 public beta. Manual revision 1.0, 4 October 2026.

Questions, bug reports and beta feedback: info@thewavlab.com

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1. Welcome

Patch Cable is a free macOS app for creating **virtual audio cables**: audio devices that exist only in software. Whatever one app plays into a Patch Cable device comes straight out of that device's input, ready for another app to record, stream or process.

Patch Cable can also **capture audio from individual apps**. Pick Music, a browser, a video call or your DAW and send just that app's sound into a device, with its own volume, mute and level meters. You can capture all system audio or a microphone or interface input the same way, then decide on a drag-and-drop canvas exactly which channel goes where.

Typical uses:

- Send a browser, game or music player into OBS, Zoom or a podcast recorder on its own channels.
- Record a video call into your DAW, with the far end and your microphone on separate tracks.
- Bring the output of an app that has no device selector into a DAW.
- Build a multichannel bus (up to 64 channels) that several apps feed at once.

2. Installation and system requirements

- **macOS 14.4 (Sonoma) or later.** Per-app capture uses Core Audio process taps, which arrived in macOS 14.4.
- **Apple Silicon or Intel Macs.**
- Under 5 MB of disk space.

Download `PatchCable-<version>.pkg` from [The WAV Lab's download page](#) on GitHub (releases tagged `patchcable-v...`). The installer is signed and notarized by Apple. Double-click it and follow the steps. It installs:

- **Patch Cable.app** in `/Applications`
- **PatchCable.driver**, an audio driver, in `/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/HAL`

At the end of installation the macOS audio system (Core Audio) restarts, so **sound stops for a moment**. Close audio apps, especially your DAW, before you install. Patch Cable then opens by itself.

To update, download and run the newer installer. Your devices, sources and wiring are kept, and each device keeps the same internal ID, so apps and DAW sessions that use it still find it after an update.

3. Quick start

This example sends Music into a virtual device and lets you hear it.

1. **Open Patch Cable.** On first launch there is already one device, **Patch Cable 1** (2 channels). It appears in **System Settings** → **Sound** and in every audio app's device list.
2. **Play something in Music.**
3. **Click Add Source** under SOURCES and choose **Music** from Running Applications. The first time you capture an app, macOS asks you to allow audio capture: click **Allow**.

4. **Watch the meters.** Music's card and the device's Channel 1 and 2 meters move. Patch Cable connected Music's left and right to channels 1 and 2 for you.
5. **Click Add Monitor** under MONITORS and choose your speakers or headphones. You now hear what is on the device.
6. **Use the device.** In OBS, Zoom, QuickTime, your DAW or any recorder, choose **Patch Cable 1** as the input. That app now receives Music.

Tip: open the **•••** menu on Music's card and turn on **Mute Original App Audio**. Music then goes only into Patch Cable and stops playing from your speakers, except through the monitor if you added one.

4. How Patch Cable works

Every Patch Cable device is a **loopback**: its output and input are joined. Audio played to the device's output comes back out of its input with no extra delay or processing.

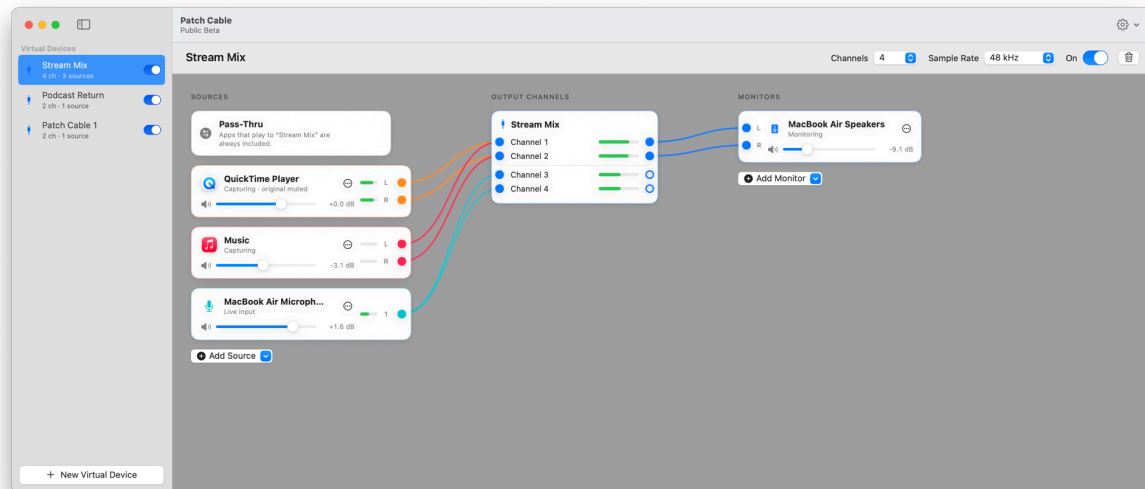
There are two ways to get audio onto a device:

- **Pass-Thru.** Any app whose output is set to the device plays into it directly. This always works, even when the Patch Cable app is not running.
- **Sources.** Patch Cable captures an app, all system audio or a hardware input and mixes it onto the device channels you choose, without changing that app's own settings.

Everything on a device (pass-thru plus all sources) is mixed together. Any app that records from the device hears that mix, and so does any **monitor** you have added.

Devices are stored by the audio driver, so they exist from startup, even before Patch Cable opens. Sources and monitors are run by the app: they work while Patch Cable is open, including when only its menu bar icon is showing, and stop when you quit it.

5. The window



The Patch Cable window: the device list on the left, and the routing canvas for the selected device on the right.

- **Sidebar.** Your virtual devices, each with its channel count, number of sources and an on/off switch. **New Virtual Device** (⌘N) is at the bottom.
- **Device header.** Name, Channels, Sample Rate, the **On** switch and the delete (trash) button for the selected device.
- **Routing canvas**, in three columns:
 - **SOURCES:** the Pass-Thru card, one card per source, and **Add Source**.
 - **OUTPUT CHANNELS:** the device's channels, with a level meter for each.
 - **MONITORS:** speakers or headphones you are listening on, and **Add Monitor**.
- **Gear menu** (top right): launch at login, update checks, feedback, shortcuts to Sound settings and Audio MIDI Setup, and Uninstall.

Banners at the top of the canvas tell you when an update is available, when the audio driver isn't loaded, or when Patch Cable needs microphone access.

6. Virtual devices

Creating, renaming and deleting

- **Create:** click **New Virtual Device** or press ⌘N. New devices are named Patch Cable 2, Patch Cable 3 and so on, with 2 channels.
- **Rename:** click the name in the device header and type. The new name shows up in Sound settings and in other apps right away.

- **Delete:** click the trash button, or right-click the device in the sidebar and choose **Delete...** Apps that were using it switch to another device.

You can create as many devices as you need.

Channels and sample rate

- **Channels:** 1, 2, 4, 6, 8, 10, 12, 16, 24, 32, 48 or 64.
- **Sample Rate:** 44.1, 48, 88.2, 96, 176.4 or 192 kHz. Like any audio device, the rate can also be changed by another app (a DAW, for example) or in Audio MIDI Setup, and Patch Cable follows that change.

Sources are converted to the device's rate automatically, with one exception: see *Audio inputs and sample rate* in section 7.

Turning a device off

The **On** switch (also in the sidebar and the menu bar) removes the device from macOS without deleting its setup. While it is off, it disappears from Sound settings and other apps, and its sources and monitors stop. Turn it back on and everything returns as it was.

7. Sources

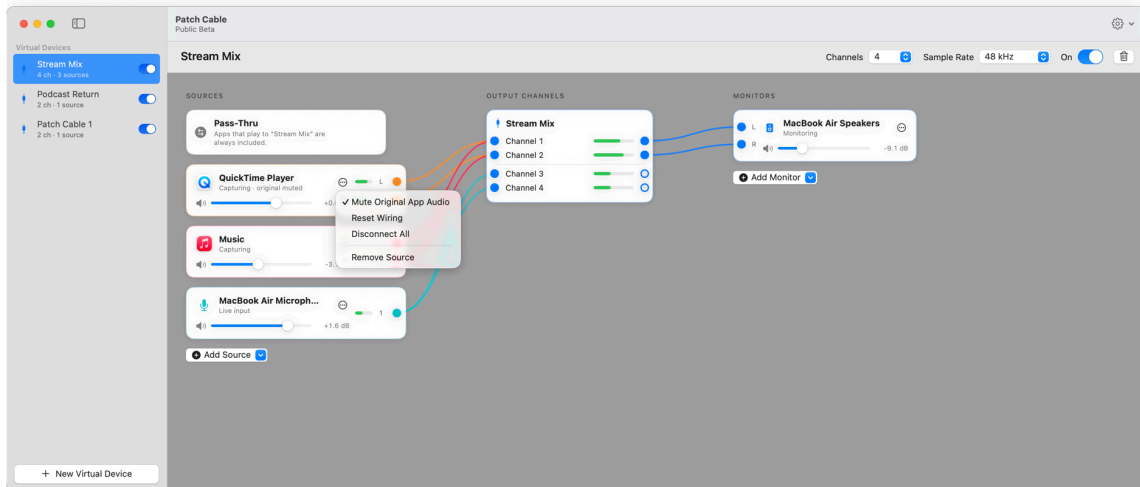
Click **Add Source** and choose one of these:

Source	What it captures
Running Applications	One app's audio, including its helper processes (browsers play audio from helpers). The list shows apps that are running now.
Choose Application...	Any app in your Applications folder, even if it isn't running yet. Its card says <i>Not running</i> until you open the app, then capture starts by itself.
System Audio	Everything your Mac plays, except Patch Cable itself, so that monitors don't feed back into the capture.
Audio Input Devices	A microphone, audio interface input or other input device, with its channel count shown.

The source card

- **Status line:** *Capturing*, *Capturing · original muted*, *Live input*, *Muted*, *Not running* or *Not connected*. Problems appear in orange.
- **Speaker button:** mutes the source.

- **Volume slider:** from silence ($-\infty$ dB) up to +3.5 dB. Double-click the slider row to reset it to 0 dB.
- **Meters:** one per channel, after the volume and mute settings.
- **Ports:** one coloured dot per channel (L/R for stereo), used for wiring. Each source has its own wire colour.



The ... menu on a source card.

The ... menu

- **Mute Original App Audio / Mute Original System Audio** (app and system sources only): silences the app's normal output while Patch Cable captures it. The sound goes only to the Patch Cable device. This is useful when you want to hear the app only through a monitor, or not at all.
- **Reset Wiring:** puts back the default connections.
- **Disconnect All:** removes every wire from this source.
- **Remove Source.**

Audio inputs and sample rate

An input device is read at its own clock. If it runs at a different sample rate from the Patch Cable device, the card shows, for example, *Running at 44.1 kHz (device is 48 kHz)*, and the input may be switched to the device's rate. For the cleanest results, set the input and the Patch Cable device to the same rate.

8. Wiring

A wire connects one source channel to one device channel, or one device channel to one monitor channel. When you add a source or monitor, Patch Cable wires it for you:

- Channel 1 to channel 1, channel 2 to channel 2, and so on, for as many channels as both sides have.
- A **mono** source (most microphones) feeds both channels 1 and 2, so it is centred in a stereo device.
- A stereo source into a **1-channel** device is summed to mono.

To change the wiring:

- **Connect:** drag from any port to a port in the next column. A dashed line follows the pointer. You can drag in either direction.
- **Disconnect one wire:** hover over it until it turns red, then click it.
- **Disconnect everything on a port:** right-click the port and choose **Disconnect All**.

One output can feed several inputs, and several outputs can feed one input, where they are mixed. For example, wire a stereo app to channels 1–2 and a microphone to channels 3–4 of a 4-channel device, and a recorder sees them as separate tracks.

Unwired channels are silent. When you lower a device's channel count, wires to the channels that are removed are ignored, and they come back if you raise it again.

9. Monitors

A monitor plays a Patch Cable device on real speakers or headphones, so you can hear what you are routing. Click **Add Monitor** and choose an output device. Its channel count is shown in the menu.

- The monitor card has a mute button and a volume slider, like a source.
- Wire the device's right-hand ports (the outputs of OUTPUT CHANNELS) to the monitor's ports. By default, channels 1–2 go to the first two outputs.
- The **⋮** menu has **Disconnect All** and **Remove Monitor**.

Monitors are optional. Apps that record from a device receive its audio whether or not anything is monitoring it.

Feedback warning: if a microphone source and a speaker monitor share the same channels, the microphone can pick up the speakers and howl. Use headphones, or leave the microphone's channels unwired to the monitor.

10. Menu bar, login and settings

Closing the window does not stop Patch Cable. Routing keeps running and a cable icon stays in the menu bar. Its menu has:

- An on/off switch for each device.
- **Open Patch Cable...** and **Launch at Login.**
- **About Patch Cable, Send Feedback...** and **Check for Updates...**
- **Quit Patch Cable** (⌘Q), which stops all sources and monitors. Devices and pass-thru keep working.

Turn on **Launch at Login** (menu bar or gear menu) if you want your sources running from startup.

The **gear menu** in the window also has **Check for Updates Automatically, Open Sound Settings..., Open Audio MIDI Setup** and **Uninstall Patch Cable....** The Help menu has **Send Feedback..., the Licence Agreement** and a link to The WAV Lab website.

Your setup is saved automatically as you work, in `~/Library/Application Support/Patch Cable/config.json`.

11. Example setups

Stream or record a browser and a microphone separately

1. Create a device, name it *Stream Mix* and set **Channels** to 4.
2. Add your browser as a source. It wires to channels 1–2.
3. Add your microphone as a source, then rewire it to channels 3–4.
4. In OBS or your DAW, record from *Stream Mix*: channels 1–2 are the browser and 3–4 the microphone.

Record a video call into your DAW

1. Create a device named *Call*.
2. Add Zoom, Teams or the browser you use for calls as a source.
3. In your DAW, record a track from *Call* and another from your microphone.

Send DAW playback to another app

Set your DAW's output to a Patch Cable device (pass-thru) and pick the same device as the input in the other app. Add a monitor on that device to keep hearing the DAW.

Capture an app that has no output selector

Add the app as a source and turn on **Mute Original App Audio**. Its sound now goes only into Patch Cable, and other apps can record it from there.

12. Privacy, permissions and updates

- **Microphone access** lets Patch Cable read hardware inputs and its own devices for monitors and meters. If it is denied, a banner offers **Open Privacy Settings**.
- **Audio capture** is requested by macOS the first time an app or System Audio source starts. Manage it in **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security**.
- **Your audio stays on your Mac**. Patch Cable never records, stores or sends audio anywhere.
- **Update checks**: Patch Cable looks at The WAV Lab's GitHub releases shortly after launch and then about once a day. When there is a newer version, it shows a banner and a menu bar item that open the release page. It never downloads or installs anything itself. Turn this off with **Check for Updates Automatically** in the gear menu. Nothing else leaves your Mac.
- **Send Feedback...** opens an email to info@thewavlab.com in your mail app, with system details (Patch Cable and macOS versions) filled in. If no mail app is set up, the details are copied to the clipboard instead. Nothing is sent until you send the email.

13. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to do
Banner: "The Patch Cable audio driver isn't loaded."	Restart your Mac if you have just installed Patch Cable. Otherwise run the installer again.
A source says <i>Not running</i> .	Open the app. Capture starts by itself as soon as it is running.
An input says <i>Not connected</i> .	Plug the device back in. Patch Cable reconnects automatically.
An app source shows no level.	Make sure the app is actually playing, and that audio capture is allowed for Patch Cable in Privacy & Security. Check that the source isn't muted and has wires.
I can't hear anything.	Add a monitor and check its wires and volume. If you turned on Mute Original, the app is heard only through Patch Cable.
I hear the app twice, or with an echo.	You are hearing both the app's own output and a monitor. Turn on Mute Original App Audio , or remove the monitor.
Howling or feedback.	A microphone is reaching your speakers through a monitor. Use headphones or unwire the microphone's channels from the monitor.
An input says <i>Running at ... (device is ...)</i> .	Set the input and the Patch Cable device to the same sample rate in the device header or Audio MIDI Setup.
A device is missing from other apps.	Check that it is switched On . Some apps only read the device list when they start, so restart the app.

Still stuck? Choose **Send Feedback...** in the app, or write to info@thewavlab.com. Describe what you were routing and what happened.

14. Uninstalling

Open Patch Cable and choose **gear menu** → **Uninstall Patch Cable...**, then enter an administrator password. This removes the app and its audio driver, and Core Audio restarts, so sound stops for a moment. Your saved setup in `~/Library/Application Support/Patch Cable` is kept. Delete that folder too if you want to remove everything.

You can also uninstall from Terminal:

```
sudo "/Applications/Patch Cable.app/Contents/Resources/uninstall.sh"
```

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